



VOX

PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

TIER 1 • FOUNDATIONS

A ProVox Publication



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In association with

PROVOX

PROFESSIONAL ENGLISH COACHING

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WELCOME TO VOX

As a bilingual living abroad who has coached English professionally for over a decade, I've learned a lot about language and communication. Over the years one thing has become clear: speaking good English and speaking it professionally are very different things.

I've worked with many international professionals whose English was strong. They were confident speakers, but in the workplace they struggled. Not because their English was bad, but because no one had really taught them how to use it professionally. No one had taught them how to handle misunderstandings, how to add real value in group discussions, or how to be assertive while maintaining professionalism and protecting relationships.

These are the types of skills Vox was built to teach.

Every session in this program focuses on a real communication skill, practiced in real workplace contexts, with immediate application to your professional life. This is not a grammar course. It is not a textbook. It is a *coaching program*. You'll see the best results when you share your work experience, real challenges, and honest questions in every session.

Brad Herdt,
VOX Author



ABOUT THE VOX PROGRAM

Vox — Professional Communication is grounded in established principles of adult learning. These include andragogy and communicative language teaching. Every session follows a complete learning cycle: understand, practice, apply, and reflect. Skills are always taught using real workplace context, and learning is measured by how professionals can communicate, not what they can remember.

The program revolves around **4 Core Skills** that help form the foundation of professional communication. These skills are as follows:

Core Skill 1 — Communication Etiquette

Teaches how to control tone, use tact strategically, ask questions professionally, express opinions, and handle disagreement.

Core Skill 2 — Clarity and Accuracy

Shows how to recognize implied meaning, communicate with precision, ask clear questions, and prevent and handle misunderstandings.

Core Skill 3 — Participating in Discussions

Develops how to join group discussions, stay on track, add depth and meaning, manage speaking time, and close discussions with clarity.

Core Skill 4 — Professional Assertiveness

Teaches how to be firm and direct, set boundaries, challenge ideas, communicate with confidence, all while respecting others and protecting relationships.

HOW TO USE THIS PROGRAM

This publication is a coaching tool. It is designed to be used with your ProVox coach. Each session is structured to guide a live coaching conversation. Your coach will lead you through each section during your time together.

EACH SESSION HAS 4 SECTIONS

1

UNDERSTAND THE SKILL

This section introduces the skill and explains why it's relevant to your professional life. Includes a discussion to activate your existing knowledge and open the conversation.

PRACTICE THE SKILL

2

This section develops the skill through targeted exercises. You will listen, analyze, speak, and apply. All exercises focus on real workplace situations. Your coach will guide you through each exercise and provide feedback.

3

USE YOUR SKILLS

This section helps you combine and apply the techniques of the session in a scenario or role-play exercise. Your coach will play a role alongside you. You will also discuss how to use the skill in your own job, and the session ends by setting a personal goal.

CONTINUE BUILDING

4

This section asks a question to pique your curiosity and encourages you to continue building the skill on your own. You will be led to outside resources that will strengthen your professional communication skills.

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CORE SKILL 1

COMMUNICATION ETIQUETTE



• etiquette

the customary code of polite behavior in society or among members of a particular profession or group

INTRODUCTION

In professional environments, how you communicate changes how others perceive you. Communication etiquette is the ability to control your tone, language, and reactions in order to maintain professionalism in any situation.

Etiquette is not just about being polite. It is about awareness, control, and protecting professional relationships. This section will teach you *how to communicate professionally*.

You will learn to:

- Control tone & perception
- Soften language strategically
- Frame questions intelligently
- Express opinions logically
- Disagree professionally

PROFESSIONAL TONE

Communication Etiquette - Session 1



FOCUS:

What makes communication professional, and why learning to control tone is an essential skill

What do you think defines professional communication?

UNDERSTAND THE SKILL

Professional communication is much more than the words we choose. It's about how we use those words and how others receive them. Two people can say the exact same thing, but leave very different impressions.

The way we communicate changes how others view us. Colleagues, managers, and clients form opinions quickly, often based on a single conversation. Professionals who can control their tone and communication style will have a better reputation and working relationships. This session will help us develop this skill.

DISCUSS:

- When you think about professional communication at your job, what does it include?
- Which do you think is harder to control: the words you choose, or the tone behind them?

PRACTICE THE SKILL

Practice changing tone to sound professional



CORE IDEA

Before we can have good communication etiquette, we need to understand one core idea: **how you sound**.

How you sound, is also referred to as “**tone**”. It’s not just about the words you use. It is about how you make others feel. The same sentence can make others think you are polite, angry, annoyed, or impatient. The tone is influenced by *the words we emphasize* and *the feelings behind our voice*. Tone is often the difference between professional and unprofessional communication.

LISTEN: Two sentences will be repeated several times, notice how tone and emphasis change the meaning each time

AUDIO 1.1

SENTENCE 1

How did emphasizing different words change the meaning?

SENTENCE 2

How did changing tone reveal different feelings of the speaker?

INTENTION vs. PERCEPTION

Our intention is not always how we sound

- Efficient can sound **impatient**
- Direct can sound **critical**
- Honest can sound **blunt**

PRACTICE: Change the sound and meaning of these phrases by adjusting your tone

- Can you help me with this project?
- I didn’t say you made the project fail.
- I never said we should change the deadline.

RECOGNIZING UNPROFESSIONAL TONE

Professionals know how to choose the right words and control how those words sound. They also listen carefully to others and try to discern their tone and its meaning. This helps them know how they should respond. For us to communicate professionally, we must learn and develop these skills.

In the following sessions, you will learn practical techniques that help you change your tone appropriately and show good communication etiquette.

DISCUSS:

- What different kinds of tones can sound unprofessional?

SPEAK: Re-phrase these sentences to sound more professional

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 1. This is wrong, I do not agree. | 4. Just fix it and send it back. |
| 2. This does not make sense. | 5. No that's not possible. We cannot. |
| 3. You made a mistake. | 6. Why is this taking so long? |

CULTURAL AWARENESS

Many Asian cultures feel free to speak directly about many different topics. However, in most English speaking cultures, professional communication isn't just about the words we say, it's often about what we *do not* say.

TALK TO YOUR COACH:

- What culture do you deal with most at your job?
- What topics may be best to avoid when talking to them?

USE YOUR SKILLS

Identify how you can apply this skill at your job

ROLE-PLAY: Improve the dialogue by using professional communication

SCENARIO: A team member asks their manager about feedback on a report they submitted two days ago

Employee: Did you read my report yet?

Manager: Not yet. I've been busy with the client meetings this week.

Employee: I sent it two days ago. I need to know if it's okay so I can move forward.

Manager: I said I've been busy. I'll get to it when I can.

Employee: Okay but the deadline is Friday. This is holding me up.

DISCUSS:

- Which parts of this conversation sound unprofessional? Why?
- What tone is the employee creating, even if their concern is reasonable?

Now repeat the conversation. Keep the same message, but adjust the employee's tone to sound more professional and respectful.



This week, what is your goal regarding how you sound when talking to co-workers?

Name two **specific situations** where you can use the skills you learned in this session:

☐

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At the next session, discuss your results with your coach.

Why can a single conversation permanently change the way people see you?

If you're curious, check out these resources



► [Watch \(8 min\)](#)

How to Change Tone of Voice



► [Read](#)

Why Tone of Voice Matters in Workplace Communication & How to Improve It

COMMUNICATING WITH TACT

Communication Etiquette - Session 2



FOCUS:

Why choosing the right words and tone affect how others receive your message, and how they respond to you

What type of communication makes others want to cooperate with us?

UNDERSTAND THE SKILL

To show good communication etiquette, our professional tone must go with the right words. The specific words and phrases we choose affect how others feel about us. If they feel we respect them, they will likely be willing to cooperate with us.

This is what it means to communicate with tact. It means using appropriate words that make others feel respected, even when being direct or talking about serious issues.

In this session we will use tact to make requests, give feedback, and express concern in a way that invites cooperation from others.

DISCUSS:

- If professionals often communicate without tact, how could this affect the workplace?
- Is it possible to be both direct and tactful at the same time? Or does being tactful always mean softening the truth?